

Critical Essay

by Md. Miraz Hossain

Astir

Fragmentation and Unity in a Century of Anti-Colonial Resistance, 1757–1930

Instructor's assessment:

The assignment was marked “*Excellent*” by Dr. Salimullah Khan — a noted Bangladeshi public intellectual and a famously exacting marker — and received the only A awarded in the class.

Your work

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Dr. Salimullah Khan • Jan 16,
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Excellent

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About this artifact

These are the two essays I wrote for History of Modern South Asia, presented together because they tell one story across a century. Part I examines the resistance to Company rule between 1757 and 1857 — widespread, genuine, but fragmented, never quite tied into a single movement. Part II picks up the same problem and its eventual solution: how Gandhi, in the decade around 1920, finally unified India’s contradictory class interests into a mass nationalist movement. Read in sequence, they trace the long arc from scattered revolt to organised nationalism. Both have been lightly edited from the originals for the portfolio — citations standardised, prose tightened — with the argument and sourcing left intact.

A note on the throughline. Both essays return, deliberately, to a single word Sugata Bose and Ayesha Jalal use for nineteenth-century India: that the society was “astir.” The first essay shows that astir society in its fragmented form — peasants, tribals, weavers, princes, all resisting, none combining. The second shows the figure who finally gave that unrest a common shape. The question that joins them is the one that has never stopped mattering in South Asia: how does a fractured society come to act as one against a power it cannot individually resist? I draw, in both, a careful parallel to Bangladesh’s own 2024 mass uprising, because the question is not only historical.

Part I: Resistance to the Company Raj in Colonial South Asia, 1757–1857

Introduction

The arrival of the British in India shaped the whole subsequent course of South Asian history. The East India Company came as a trading concern and, through political cunning and the help of local collaborators, gradually became a political power, establishing colonial rule after the defeat of Siraj-ud-Daulah at the Battle of Plassey in 1757. The transition was anything but smooth. Colonial consolidation under the Company met sustained resistance: as Bose and Jalal (2023) put it, Indian society was “astir throughout the period of colonial consolidation under the company state,” with diverse sections — “rural magnates, peasants, tribals and urban artisans” — opposing Company control and exploitation (p. 133). As people felt the pressure of Company extraction, they resisted, in different ways and in different regions. The defining feature of that resistance, and the argument of this essay, is that it was real and widespread but never unified — a society astir, not yet a movement.

Exploitation and frustration

The Permanent Settlement of 1793, “by which a private property right in revenue collection was assigned to the zamindars of Bengal” (Bose & Jalal, 2023, p. 109), alienated large parts of agrarian society, placing financial pressure on landlords and cultivators alike. As Mann (2014) describes it, the policy was sweeping: “with this single stroke of the pen, all legal titles of peasants regarding land were cancelled and they were turned into mere tenants, whilst the zamindars — as ‘landowners’ yet not proprietors — were henceforth made solely responsible for the payment of revenues” (p. 143). The distress was not confined to Bengal. The Ryotwari and Mahalwari systems in Madras and northern India imposed comparable burdens, impoverishing rural communities and sharpening local tensions.

Religious and cultural resistance

The British approached Indian society through three governing ideas — free trade, utilitarianism, and evangelism — whose expectations “remained largely unfulfilled and misplaced” (Bose & Jalal, 2023, p. 119). The evangelical impulse, aimed at weakening Hinduism and Islam and converting subjects to Christianity, drew the fiercest response. Reform measures read by Indians as cultural intrusion compounded the resentment: even the abolition of sati in 1829 generated organised objection not necessarily in defence of the practice but against colonial interference in Indian custom — a society that “stoutly opposed colonial legal interference in Indian social customs” (Bose & Jalal, 2023, p. 127).

Reformist Islamic currents, including the followers of Shah Waliullah and Sayyid Ahmad of Rai Bareilly, pursued religious and social renewal, while the Faraizi movement in Bengal framed resistance to colonial encroachment as a religious duty and a return to Islamic purity. Both Hindu and Muslim leaders came to see the British as a cultural and religious threat, and that shared perception strengthened local resistance — a dynamic not unlike the way disparate groups in Bangladesh found common cause against the Hasina government in 2024, when an external threat to shared values did the work of unification that ordinary politics could not.

Tribal resistance and rural insurrection

Tribal communities in the forests and hills were among the Company’s most determined opponents. As Bose and Jalal (2023) note, the “company raj redefined Indian forests as separate from the agricultural plains before launching a major onslaught on forests and forest peoples,” with large-scale deforestation disrupting tribal lands and forcing money into tribal economies (p. 121). The Mappila Muslims rose against Hindu landlords and British officials; the poligars, warrior lords in regions such as Tamil Nadu, resisted encroachment on their authority; weavers and craftsmen ruined by cheap British manufactures protested in Delhi and other northern towns; and grain riots erupted in Madras in 1806, 1833, and 1854 in response to scarcity and colonial economic policy. The Bhils, Kols, and Santhals mounted serious resistance in central and eastern India, most notably the Santhal rebellion of 1855–56, a reaction to land alienation and exploitation by British-backed landlords (Subramanian, 2010).

Mann (2014) records that the “British were always wary of rebellions of discontented peasants or ‘tribal savages’” (p. 37), and notes how the colonial state cast these uprisings as primitive and irrational, justifying their suppression through an Orientalist lens that depicted the communities as in need of civilisation. This is precisely the logic Said (1978) named in Orientalism, by which colonial authority represents indigenous resistance as inherently uncivilised in order to justify repression. The uprisings were nothing of the kind: they were coordinated acts of defiance aimed at preserving local autonomy against the Company’s intrusion into existing socio-economic structures (Bose & Jalal, 2023).

Resistance from local elites and princely states

The Subsidiary Alliance system introduced by Lord Wellesley was deeply resented for forcing Indian rulers into vassalage, and leaders such as Tipu Sultan of Mysore and the Maratha Confederacy saw British expansion as a direct threat to their sovereignty (Subramanian, 2010, p. 70). The Doctrine of Lapse under Dalhousie, which annexed states lacking a direct heir, deepened the discontent (Bose & Jalal, 2023, p. 104). The Marathas, who until 1761 had controlled substantial territory across northern and central India (Subramanian, 2010, p. 69), fought to protect regional autonomy through the Anglo-Maratha Wars of 1775–1818 before their eventual subjugation. Mysore under Haidar Ali and Tipu Sultan resisted with strong military strategy and a French alliance until Tipu’s defeat and death in the Fourth Anglo-Mysore War of 1799. The Sikh Empire under Ranjit Singh held its sovereignty through the early nineteenth century, until internal division after his death in 1839 opened the way to British control by 1849. Awadh, strained by subsidiary alliance, resisted out of frustration at lost sovereignty and financial exploitation before its annexation in 1856 — a direct prelude to the revolt that followed.

1857 as the culmination

The Rebellion of 1857 began over a technical grievance and became something far larger. The new rifle cartridges “were rumoured to have been smeared with cow and pig fat, repugnant to Hindus and Muslims alike, and this was widely seen as an insidious plot by the infidels to pollute Indians before forcing their conversion to Christianity”

(Bose & Jalal, 2023, p. 137). What started as a military mutiny at Meerut spread into a mass civilian uprising. Bose and Jalal argue that the revolt was the culmination of decades of exploitation, uniting diverse social groups under a common cause; what gave it “its unique character was the convergence of multiple strands of resistance, the expansion of scale and a new level of intensity” (p. 135). Talbot (2016) reads the unity on display as proof of the possibility of organised, pan-Indian resistance, noting that “for some Muslim rebels the struggle was seen as a jihad” (p. 86). The annexation of states under the Doctrine of Lapse produced figures such as Rani Lakshmibai of Jhansi, who became a prominent face of the rebellion. The parallel to 2024 is hard to miss: Hasina’s long authoritarian rule, like the Company’s accumulated exploitation, finally converged a fractured society into a single uprising once the grievances became general enough.

Conclusion

Resistance to the Company Raj came from many sources at once — economic exploitation, religious and cultural conflict, tribal insurrection, and elite opposition. Indian society was, in Bose and Jalal’s word, genuinely “astir.” But for most of the century that unrest stayed plural and local: a thousand resistances rather than one. Even 1857, the moment they converged most fully, was a convergence of strands rather than a unified movement with a shared programme. That distinction — between a society in revolt and a society organised — is the unfinished business the next essay takes up.

Part II: Gandhi's Mass Appeal: Unifying Class Interests in the Decade of Independence

The rise of a leader for the masses

Through the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, Indians had resisted British rule by constitutional means — the “prayers and petitions” of the early Congress — by individual revolutionary violence, and by failed attempts at armed insurrection, particularly during the First World War. None of these had won significant concessions by 1919, and the isolated armed efforts had been crushed. The resistance described in the previous essay had not gone away; it had simply never found a single shape.

According to Bandyopadhyay (2004), peasant protests against landlord oppression had occurred across India — in Bengal, in Malabar among the Moplah peasants, in Sitapur in Awadh, in Mewar in Rajasthan — over rent hikes and illegal cesses, alongside religiously rooted revolts such as the Kuka rising in Punjab in 1872. But none of these could tie the others into a single string. That changed when Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi emerged as a leader able to mobilise support across India's social spectrum, and the localised uprisings evolved into broader Gandhian mass movements by 1921 (Bandyopadhyay, 2004, p. 195). The Congress he led primarily represented the middle and wealthier peasantry and the industrial capitalists, yet Gandhi's appeal reached past those class interests to the urban professionals and the poor. The apparent paradox resolves once you consider his particular political philosophy, his shrewd pursuit of power, and the wider conditions of the moment.

After returning to India, Gandhi spent more than a year travelling the country to understand its socio-political reality. Between 1917 and 1918 he tested his doctrine of non-violent non-cooperation in three local movements: in Kheda, where Gujarati farmers resisted excessive revenue demands; in Ahmedabad, where he mediated between textile workers and their industrialist employers; and in Champaran in Bihar,

where he took up the cause of farmers forced to grow indigo for European planters. As Bandyopadhyay (2004) observes, “indigo plantation in Champaran had to wait for Gandhi’s intervention in 1917 for its complete demise” (p. 194). These were local fights, but they were precisely what built his reputation as a leader of mass mobilisation. His genius was a strategy that could address several class interests at once while carrying moral authority — a platform broad enough to hold different aspirations yet narrow enough to keep them under a single anti-colonial flag. As Bose and Jalal (2023) put it, “Gandhi’s political genius fused love for a territorial homeland with the extra-territorial loyalty of religion in the mass nationalist movement of 1920” (p. 195).

Urban professionals saw expediency

For urban professionals sceptical of Gandhi’s methods, pragmatism usually outweighed ideological doubt. As Bose and Jalal (2023) note, “urban professionals not impressed by Gandhi’s political ideology nevertheless accepted his leadership as a matter of expediency” (p. 206). They accepted it because he had demonstrated the capacity to mobilise mass support and to confront British authority more forcefully than they could; the three local agitations of 1917–1918 had established his credentials as an effective leader of mass action.

The promise of swaraj inspired the poor

For the poor and socially marginalised, Gandhi offered both immediate psychological satisfaction and the hope of change, even though his economic programme was essentially conservative. His “somewhat rash promise of swaraj within a year aroused millenarian hopes in the remotest villages of India” (Bose & Jalal, 2023). After the Salt March of 1930 he became a hero to the poor; as Mann (2014) records, “Gandhi’s Eleven Point Programme complemented the campaign with further concrete political demands which, in substance, meant purna swaraj. All in all, the salt campaign contributed decisively to Gandhi’s myth as a political leader of the non-violent campaigns” (p. 74). The charkha and the promotion of khadi gave the poorest a tangible way to take part in the movement: the spinning wheel as symbol “was not merely economic but also deeply cultural, creating a connection between tradition and modern nationalism” (Bandyopadhyay, 2004, p. 297).

Gandhi's contradictions

Gandhi tied the classes together with real success, but his leadership was not without contradiction. “The Gandhian strategy often navigated contradictions between his vision of a moral economy and the radical demands of peasant and worker movements” (Subramanian, 2010, p. 223). His transformation of the Congress into a mass political party was a major achievement, yet he was frequently wary of popular movements that turned radical. At every important juncture of the 1920s non-cooperation movement, Bose and Jalal (2023) note, “we find the Gandhian Congress ready to press the brakes, fearful of people running ahead of the leadership and redefining the organization’s cherished goal of swaraj.”

The clearest example is the doctrine of trusteeship, which Bose and Jalal present as a “palliative remedy” for the poor. As Banerjee-Dube (2014) observes, the doctrine, “while morally persuasive, was criticized for being impractical and for failing to address structural inequalities in Indian society” (p. 265). It acknowledged economic inequality but sought to fix it through moral reform rather than structural change: the rich were to be trustees of their wealth for society’s benefit, their privileges left unchallenged.

A delicate balancing act

“The non-cooperation movement brought together a diverse coalition of urban elites, rural peasants, and the marginalized, illustrating Gandhi’s ability to unify class interests under a common cause” (Sarkar, 2014, p. 158). Several factors made him a leader across classes. His moral authority and personal charisma mattered enormously — “images of Gandhi as Mahatma were crafted by the spread of popular rumour” (Bose & Jalal, 2023), and his ascetic life and ethical leadership resonated widely; Mann (2014) notes his “ability to channel the frustrations of diverse groups into disciplined, non-violent resistance” (p. 63). His strategic flexibility was equally important: he presented non-violence to the Congress “as a political weapon and not as a moral philosophy,” which let him keep control of the movement’s direction while holding broad support. He showed organisational innovation, reorganising the Provincial Congresses along linguistic lines because “the emotive power of anti-colonial sentiment often sprang from linguistic nationalisms,” and he extended mobilisation to women —

as Talbot (2016) records, “female mobilization in nationalist struggle became more sustained in the Gandhian era” (p. 105). And he kept control of potentially volatile mass action through an insistence on discipline and loyalty, casting his satyagrahis as soldiers.

The apparent contradiction makes sense once situated in the broader anti-colonial struggle. Gandhi’s Congress, though mainly representing middle- and upper-class interests, offered the strongest available vehicle for resistance to British power. As Bose and Jalal observe, “the perception of Gandhi as a veritable messiah explains why, despite ‘disparate aspirations and grievances’, the main ingredients of Indian nationalism became somehow generalized into unities stronger than their own contradictions.” Critics such as Rabindranath Tagore objected to elements of the programme — of the focus on spinning and weaving, Tagore asked, “is this the call of the New Age to new creation?” — but such criticism did little to weaken Gandhi’s capacity to hold the factions together.

Conclusion

In Gandhi’s case ideological consistency was the least important thing, and arguably the least examined; it was political applicability that defined his leadership. His genius was to build a movement that could contain diverse class interests while keeping enough unity and discipline to challenge British rule. The Congress under him largely represented the middle and upper classes, yet it opened its doors to others so long as they would join the nationalist movement, even as the more radical aspirations of those groups were largely contained. That delicate balancing act explains why a socially varied coalition — contrasting interests, intense grievances, periodic disappointment with Gandhi’s choices — nevertheless accepted his leadership through the pivotal decades of the freedom struggle. Where the resistance of the Company century stayed astir but fragmented, Gandhi was the figure who finally gave the unrest a single shape. That is the arc these two essays, read together, are meant to trace.

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